# Leadership Tool: Anchoring Change and Reinforcing Success Through Coaching

Anchoring change in coaching refers to *the process of solidifying new behaviors or skills in employees so they become long-lasting and habitual*. In the context of leadership, this means guiding employees through their development in a way that fosters permanent improvement rather than temporary adjustment. Anchoring change requires more than just teaching new techniques—it involves creating an environment where employees consistently practice and integrate those behaviors into their daily routines. By doing so, leaders help employees make sustainable changes that can continue to benefit both the individual and the organization long after the initial coaching period has ended.

The psychology behind behavioral change highlights the difficulty of breaking old habits and adopting new ones. Humans are naturally inclined to revert to familiar behaviors, especially when under pressure or stress. This is why consistent reinforcement is essential in coaching; without it, employees may easily slip back into old patterns. Reinforcing desired behaviors through ongoing feedback, recognition, and support helps employees stay committed to the change. As they receive positive reinforcement, employees are more likely to view the new behavior as beneficial and are more inclined to internalize it as part of their long-term professional identity.

When leaders fail to follow up or provide consistent reinforcement, employees may achieve initial success but struggle to maintain it over time. Temporary success is common when change is not embedded through repeated practice and accountability. Leaders must ensure that employees receive consistent messaging and support, allowing them to internalize the new behaviors. When change is anchored, it becomes a natural part of the employee's approach to work, leading to sustainable growth and continuous improvement.

## Reinforcing Results: The Key to Sustaining Progress

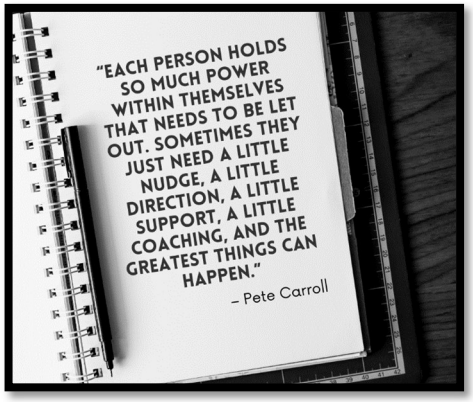
Reinforcement in coaching refers to *the consistent practice of providing positive feedback, recognition, and rewards to reinforce desired behaviors and outcomes*. In the coaching context, reinforcement serves as a critical tool for motivating employees, encouraging the repetition of successful behaviors, and ensuring long-term progress. Positive reinforcement—such as verbal recognition, written praise, or tangible rewards—affirms the value of the employee's work and

encourages them to continue performing at a high level. By acknowledging their successes, leaders help employees feel appreciated and motivate them to strive for even greater achievements. Without reinforcement, employees may lose the drive to maintain their performance or feel disconnected from the broader goals of the organization.

There are various methods leaders can use to reinforce progress. Verbal recognition during meetings, written praise in performance reviews, providing employees with new growth opportunities, or offering tangible rewards like bonuses or promotions are all effective ways to reinforce positive behavior. However, it's essential to balance both short-term and long-term reinforcement strategies. While short-term rewards like immediate praise or small incentives are critical for keeping employees engaged in the present, long-term strategies—such as career development opportunities—help ensure that motivation and progress are sustained over time. Leaders must also avoid over-reinforcing, which can lead to complacency. Employees may start expecting constant praise or rewards, which diminishes the impact of reinforcement and could reduce the intrinsic motivation to grow. A balanced approach ensures that employees remain motivated without becoming reliant on external validation.

## Specific Steps a Coach Can Take to Reinforce Results

One of the most effective steps a coach can take to reinforce results is to provide timely and constructive feedback. Feedback given immediately after key actions reinforces successful behaviors by highlighting exactly what the employee did well and how it contributed to their overall performance. Timeliness is crucial because it keeps the feedback relevant, allowing the employee to connect the behavior with the outcome while it is still fresh in their mind. Using the Situation-Behavior-Impact (SBI) feedback model is an excellent way to ensure feedback is clear and objective. The SBI model breaks down feedback into three parts: describing the specific situation, identifying the employee's behavior in that situation, and explaining the impact of the behavior. This approach prevents ambiguity, making it easier for the employee to understand which actions are worth repeating and how they contribute to their success.




In addition to feedback, celebrating both small and large successes is vital for reinforcing results. Recognizing incremental progress helps keep employees motivated during longer development processes, while celebrating major milestones reinforces the importance of their achievements. Tailoring rewards to what resonates with each individual employee is key—some may value public recognition in team meetings, while others may prefer private acknowledgment through one-on-one conversations or personalized notes. Public recognition can motivate employees who thrive on being acknowledged by their peers, while private

recognition can feel more meaningful to those who prefer personal validation. By thoughtfully recognizing successes, leaders build momentum and motivate employees to continue improving.

Empowering employees to take ownership of their growth is another critical step in reinforcing results. When employees are given autonomy and encouraged to make decisions, they become more invested in their personal and professional development. This ownership fosters a sense of responsibility, making it more likely that employees will sustain the changes they are working towards. Creating a culture of accountability supports this by encouraging employees to partner with leaders, peers, or mentors who can provide ongoing support and feedback. Accountability partners help keep employees on track, offering encouragement and guidance when necessary. Through a combination of timely feedback, recognition of progress, empowerment, and accountability, leaders can create an environment where employees feel supported, motivated, and responsible for their continued success.

## Best Practices for Anchoring Change and Reinforcing Results

The following best practices can be utilized by leaders to anchor coaching change effectively. Included is the best practice, what it means, how a leader can execute the best practice, and an example of the best practice for the leader to implement:

### Best Practice 1: Take a Personalized Approach

- ***What it means***: A personalized approach to reinforcement considers individual employee preferences and motivational drivers. Not all employees respond to the same forms of recognition or feedback, so tailoring reinforcement ensures each employee feels valued in a way that resonates with them.
- ***How to execute***: Leaders can ask employees about their preferred recognition methods during one-on-one meetings, assess their behavior to see what motivates them, and adjust reinforcement accordingly.
- ***Example***: An employee who enjoys team camaraderie may prefer public recognition in meetings, while another who values personal reflection may respond better to a private conversation or a personal note of appreciation.

### Best Practice 2: The Involvement of Peer Support

- ***What it means***: Involving peers in the reinforcement process helps create a supportive network that encourages positive behaviors. Peer recognition and feedback reinforce the importance of the employee's contributions within the team dynamic.
- ***How to execute***: Leaders can set up peer feedback systems, encourage team collaboration, and organize peer recognition moments, such as shout-outs during team meetings.
- ***Example***: A leader might initiate a "team recognition board" where employees can acknowledge each other’s contributions, fostering a sense of collective encouragement.

### Best Practice 3: Provide Consistent Communication and Transparency

- ***What it means***: Consistent, transparent communication ensures that employees understand their progress and expectations clearly. Open dialogue fosters trust and allows leaders to address challenges early on.
- ***How to execute***: Leaders should schedule regular check-ins to provide feedback, discuss challenges, and set clear expectations. They should also be transparent about the organization's goals and the employee's role in achieving them.
- ***Example***: A leader conducts weekly one-on-one meetings where they discuss the employee's progress, set clear goals for the following week, and offer honest feedback about any areas for improvement.

### Best Practice 4: Be Flexible and Adaptable

- ***What it means***: Flexibility in coaching involves adjusting approaches based on the employee's progress, needs, and any unforeseen challenges. This ensures the coaching remains relevant and effective over time.
- ***How to execute***: Leaders should monitor employees' development and be open to altering strategies, whether that means offering additional resources, shifting timelines, or changing feedback methods.
- ***Example***: A leader might notice that an employee is struggling with a new responsibility and adjusts the workload or provides extra training to support the employee's development.

### Best Practice 5: Focus on Long-term Sustainability Planning

- ***What it means***: Sustainable change requires long-term planning to ensure that the progress made during coaching is maintained. Leaders should help employees develop skills for self-assessment and continuous improvement.
- ***How to execute***: Leaders can work with employees to create a personal development plan that includes long-term goals, periodic self-assessments, and ongoing professional development opportunities.
- ***Example***: A leader helps an employee set up a quarterly self-reflection process, complete with performance metrics and milestones, ensuring they stay on track even after the coaching relationship ends.

Anchoring change and reinforcing results are critical components of successful coaching that ensure long-term employee development and sustained performance. By embedding new behaviors through consistent reinforcement and tailored feedback, leaders can help employees internalize change, making it a permanent part of their approach to work. Leaders who actively apply these principles foster an environment where employees feel supported, motivated, and empowered to succeed. As a call to action, leaders must commit to providing personalized coaching, consistent communication, and recognition that aligns with each employee's needs.